

Paradiem

The Morning Brief

JULY 22, 2026

Print Night

Chips ripped 5–8% Tuesday on ceasefire hopes as Iran hit a Qatari LNG tanker and Houthis declared a Saudi blockade — Alphabet, Tesla, ServiceNow, and TEL report tonight.

S&P 500 (TUE)	NASDAQ (TUE)	WTI (TUE)	GOLD (TUE)	FEAR & GREED
\$748.28 · ↑0.83%	\$708.97 · ↑1.85%	USO \$128.85 · ↑2.66%	GLD \$374.81 · ↑1.96%	CNN 38 Fear · data drop returned crypto fallback (33)

SECTION 01

Markets — Chip Cohort Rips as the SOX Bear-Market Signal Reverses on Ceasefire Framing While Precious Metals, Oil, and Silver All Bid on Fresh Supply Risk; Overnight Futures Fade Into Alphabet, Tesla, and ServiceNow Prints

TUESDAY'S CASH TAPE DELIVERED A BROAD-BASED CHIP BOUNCE AS TECH LED AND THE NASDAQ RETOOK PRIOR HIGHS

Per data drop, the S&P 500 closed ↑0.83% at \$748.28 and the Nasdaq ↑1.85% at \$708.97 with the Dow ↑0.69% and Russell 2K ↑1.45% — a broad-based advance led by XLK ↑2.89% (\$180.78) and paced by the FCI Growth-Hybrid chip cohort: AMD ↑8.11% at \$544.43, MRVL ↑6.68% at \$207.96, CRDO ↑5.56% at \$223.87, TSM ↑5.55% at \$424.61, LRCX ↑4.97% at \$322.00, NXPI ↑2.23% at \$273.15, and NVDA ↑1.97% at \$207.29. The composition validated Monday's tape read that the SOX bear-market print concentrated the forced-seller flow rather than opening a new leg down. Per Yahoo Finance coverage, the Nasdaq rallied ahead of the Magnificent 7 earnings sequence that begins tonight, with Alphabet, Tesla, and ServiceNow after the close. On the downside, XLP ↓0.94%, XLC ↓0.69%, and the FCI defensive-adjacent names weighed — SPGI ↓3.81% at \$431.26 and ADP ↓3.53% at \$246.22 marked the bottom of the FCI board.

OVERNIGHT FUTURES FADE ON THE QATARI LNG TANKER STRIKE AND THE HOUTHİ ANNOUNCEMENT — THE CEASEFIRE TRADE FACES ITS FIRST LIVE TEST

Per CNBC coverage of the overnight session, S&P 500 futures traded down roughly 0.4% and Nasdaq-100 futures around 0.9% while Dow futures eased about 0.2% as investors digested the Iran-Qatar tanker strike, the Houthi maritime-embargo declaration on Saudi Arabia, and the impending Alphabet-Tesla-ServiceNow print. Per Al Jazeera coverage, Iran struck the Qatari LNG tanker Al-Rekayyat while it transited near the Strait of Hormuz on Tuesday, and per

NBC News and Al Jazeera coverage, the Houthis declared a naval blockade on Saudi Arabia effective immediately — opening a Red Sea front against a US military that Reuters describes as stretched. Per Reuters headlines cited in the data drop, US forces completed an 11th consecutive night of strikes on Iran, oil extended gains to near six-week highs on new supply risks, and Hormuz vessel crossings continued to slide. The ceasefire framework that drove Tuesday's tech-led relief is now competing with a widening theater map — a

bimodal setup for the FCI Upstream sleeve as it heads into the Big Tech gauntlet. **Research Reveals Opportunities.**

S&P 500 (TUE)	\$748.28 · ↑0.83% · range \$744.18–\$749.04
NASDAQ (TUE)	\$708.97 · ↑1.85%
XLK / XLE / XLV	↑2.89% / ↑0.97% / ↑0.63%
WTI (USO TUE)	\$128.85 · ↑2.66%
BRENT (BNO TUE)	\$50.56 · ↑2.51%
GOLD (GLD TUE)	\$374.81 · ↑1.96% · two-week high per Reuters
SILVER (SLV TUE)	\$53.08 · ↑4.12%
TLT (TUE)	\$83.66 · ↓0.27%
OVERNIGHT FUTURES (WED AM)	S&P ↓0.4% · Nasdaq ↓0.9% · Dow ↓0.2% per CNBC
CARSON'S SPY SUPPORT	\$645.80 active · Tue range \$744.18–\$749.04 · not hit

PRECIOUS METALS AND SILVER JOINED THE OIL BID — THE COMPOSITION ARGUES FOR A PERSISTENT REAL-ASSET HEDGE RATHER THAN A CLEAN RISK-ON ROTATION

Per data drop, GLD advanced ↑1.96% to \$374.81 for a two-week high per Reuters coverage, while SLV surged ↑4.12% to \$53.08 alongside USO ↑2.66% (\$128.85), BNO ↑2.51% (\$50.56), and UNG ↑1.07% (\$10.40). The FCI real-asset sleeve captured the move: FCX ↑6.41% at \$62.56 and AEM ↑3.87% at \$141.62 among the top FCI advancers, with CVX ↑0.72% at \$191.07 and CNX ↑3.00% at \$33.64. The composition — equity risk bid alongside gold-silver-oil bid alongside a modest bond give-back (TLT ↓0.27%) — is consistent with markets pricing a continued higher-for-longer inflation regime with a real-asset overlay rather than a clean rate-cut narrative into the July 28–29 FOMC. Per Reuters coverage cited in the data drop headlines, gold hit a two-week high with the Fed outlook and Mideast conflict staying in focus. For the FCI Growth-Hybrid sleeve, the FCX and AEM bid alongside HUT ↑7.98% (\$108.98) and MARA ↑4.97% (\$12.25) reads as a genuine real-asset composition rather than a single-catalyst move. **The physical world matters.**

*Tuesday's cash tape delivered the chip-cohort bounce that Asian markets telegraphed overnight, but the Qatari-tanker strike and Houthi blockade announcement now put the ceasefire trade on live-fire test as Alphabet, Tesla, and ServiceNow report tonight — the composition of gold, silver, oil, and merchant silicon bidding together suggests a real-asset overlay is more durable than any single de-escalation narrative. **Research Reveals Opportunities.***

Geopolitics — Iran Strikes a Qatari LNG Tanker in Hormuz and the Houthis Declare a Naval Blockade on Saudi Arabia, Opening a Red Sea Front as Rubio Meets Wang Yi at ASEAN and Signals Washington Remains Open to Talks

THE AL-REKAYYAT STRIKE AND HOUSHI BLOCKADE TURN THE CEASEFIRE FRAMEWORK INTO A LIVE TEST — THE THEATER MAP JUST WIDENED WITHOUT AN OFF-RAMP SIGNAL

Per Al Jazeera coverage, Iran struck the Qatari LNG tanker Al-Rekayyat while it transited near the Strait of Hormuz on Tuesday, in the same window during which mediators had presented the 10-day ceasefire framework to Washington and Tehran. Per NBC News and Al Jazeera coverage, Yemen's Iran-aligned Houthis announced they were imposing a naval blockade on Saudi Arabia effective immediately, framed as retaliation for what the group described as a longstanding siege on Yemen. Per Al Jazeera coverage of Saudi statements, Riyadh condemned the announcement and warned of broader disruption to global shipping through the Bab al-Mandeb strait, which handles roughly 12% of global trade. Per Reuters headlines cited in the data drop, US forces completed an 11th consecutive night of strikes on Iran, Hormuz vessel crossings fell further, and oil extended gains to near six-week highs on new supply risk. For the FCI Upstream sleeve, the Tuesday bid captured CVX $\uparrow 0.72\%$ (\$191.07) and CNX $\uparrow 3.00\%$ (\$33.64) per data drop — a composition consistent with markets pricing a persistent physical premium rather than pricing a durable ceasefire outcome. **The physical world matters.**

RUBIO MEETS WANG YI WEDNESDAY IN MANILA — THE CHINA CHANNEL OPENS AS RUBIO SIGNALS THE US REMAINS WILLING TO NEGOTIATE BUT FRAMES IRAN AS "NOT SERIOUS"

Per Yahoo News, Al-Monitor, and BusinessWorld coverage, Secretary Rubio meets Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi on Wednesday at the ASEAN Regional Forum in Manila, with an expected focus on a possible September summit between Presidents Trump and Xi. Per the same coverage, the meeting sits against the backdrop of last week's Trump accusations of Chinese election meddling and the concurrent Iran war — the Manila forum also includes EU officials and Russian Foreign Minister Lavrov, making it the most consequential multilateral gathering since the conflict began. Per Reuters coverage, Rubio said the US is still willing to negotiate over the Iran crisis but framed Iran's posture as unserious about talks, per the same Reuters coverage conditioning continued US openness on Iran demonstrating seriousness and indicating the US would otherwise take the steps necessary to protect its interests and those of its allies. Per Yahoo Finance coverage cited in the data drop, Treasury Secretary Bessent reportedly indicated that China has cut Iranian oil purchases by 40% — a data point that, if accurate, materially narrows Iran's fiscal runway and could reshape the negotiating leverage over the

coming weeks. For the FCI Defense sleeve, LMT closed $\downarrow 0.48\%$ at \$507.09 and GD $\downarrow 0.77\%$ at \$367.73 per data drop; GD reports July 29 per General Dynamics investor relations coverage, and the LMT print is due tomorrow (Thu) before the open per Lockheed Martin investor relations. **Avoid Erosion.**

AL-REKAYYAT STRIKE	Qatari LNG tanker hit in Hormuz per Al Jazeera
HOUSHI ANNOUNCEMENT	Naval blockade on Saudi Arabia, immediate effect per NBC News
BAB AL-MANDEB VOLUME	~12% of global trade transits per Al Jazeera
US STRIKE CADENCE	11 consecutive nights per Reuters headlines in data drop
HORMUZ TRAFFIC	Vessel crossings fall further per Reuters
RUBIO × WANG YI	ASEAN Manila Wednesday · September summit signaled per Yahoo/Al-Monitor
RUBIO ON IRAN	Iran characterized as unserious · US still open per Reuters
CHINA-IRAN OIL	Purchases reportedly $\downarrow 40\%$ per Bessent via Yahoo

1. FCI Print Night — Alphabet, Tesla, ServiceNow, and TEL Report Tonight; GPC and SYF Beats Were Sold on Guidance. Per Alphastreet and CNBC coverage, Alphabet reports Q2 after the close with consensus at \$2.89 EPS on \$116.84B revenue, and the market's focus is Cloud growth against the \$462B backlog, capex commentary against the \$180B–\$190B 2026 guide, and any framing on 2027 spend. Per TradingKey and TipRanks coverage, Tesla reports the same day with consensus near \$0.52 EPS on \$25.99B revenue after 480,126 Q2 deliveries and a raised 2026 capex guide north of \$25B; ServiceNow (NOW) also reports today per Yahoo Finance framing, with Zacks Consensus near \$0.86 EPS on \$3.92B revenue and subscription revenue guidance of \$3.815B–\$3.820B representing 21%–21.5% constant-currency growth. Per data drop, TEL reports today (Zacks Est \$2.87) and closed ↑2.89% at \$209.01 into the print. Yesterday's FCI reports beat consensus but were sold on guidance: per Investing.com and GuruFocus coverage, GPC posted \$2.15 EPS versus \$2.10 consensus on \$6.5B revenue and reaffirmed 2026 EPS guidance of \$7.50–\$8.00 but flagged second-half cost pressure from the Iran conflict — the stock closed ↓2.68% at \$119.12 after touching an intraday low near \$109.50. Per StockTitan and SeekingAlpha coverage, SYF posted \$2.59 EPS versus \$2.13 consensus with \$885M net earnings and record purchase volume ↑8.1% year-over-year, and closed ↓1.63% at \$72.21. *Research Reveals Opportunities.*

2. The Hormuz-to-Bab al-Mandeb Chokepoint Map Just Widened — The FCI Upstream Sleeve Sits in the Middle of the Real-Asset Bid. Per Al Jazeera coverage, the Al-Rekayyat strike and the Houthi maritime blockade on Saudi Arabia together open a Red Sea front on top of the persistent Hormuz disruption. Per NBC News coverage, Bab al-Mandeb handles roughly 12% of global trade and the Houthi announcement threatens Saudi shipping specifically. Per data drop, Tuesday captured a broad-based real-asset composition — USO ↑2.66% (\$128.85), BNO ↑2.51% (\$50.56), GLD ↑1.96% (\$374.81) at a two-week high per Reuters coverage, SLV ↑4.12% (\$53.08), FCX ↑6.41% (\$62.56), and AEM ↑3.87% (\$141.62) — consistent with markets pricing a persistent supply-side premium rather than pricing durable de-escalation. Per Yahoo Finance coverage cited in the data drop, Treasury Secretary Bessent's framing that China has reduced Iranian oil purchases by 40% could tighten Iran's fiscal runway and, if sustained, add a lever to the negotiating framework. For the FCI Upstream sleeve, CVX ↑0.72% (\$191.07), CNX ↑3.00% (\$33.64), and OKE ↓1.85% (\$91.83) marked a mixed composition Tuesday — the widening theater map argues for discipline over positioning to either tail. *The physical world matters.*

3. Chip-Cohort Bounce Validated — The SOX Bear-Market Print Reversed Tuesday on Merchant Silicon and the Alphabet-Tesla-NOW Prints Are the Live Test. Per data drop, Tuesday's FCI Growth-Hybrid chip cohort captured broad-based gains: AMD ↑8.11% (\$544.43), MRVL ↑6.68% (\$207.96), CRDO ↑5.56% (\$223.87), TSM ↑5.55% (\$424.61), LRCX ↑4.97% (\$322.00), NXPI ↑2.23% (\$273.15), NVDA ↑1.97% (\$207.29), and QCOM ↑1.87% (\$173.50). Per Yahoo Finance coverage cited in the data drop, chip names skyrocketed as the Nasdaq rallied ahead of the Magnificent 7 sequence. Per TradingKey coverage, Alphabet's capex guide sits at \$180B–\$190B for 2026 with 2027 signaled meaningfully higher; the read-through to merchant-silicon absorption is the most consequential data point of the week. Per ServiceNow coverage cited above, management indicated Now Assist NNACV is outperforming with customers spending more than \$1M growing over 130% year-over-year — a software-side AI-demand signal that lands the same evening. Per data drop, HRMY ↑9.97% (\$36.84) topped FCI Tuesday, an outlier move worth monitoring for follow-through. Intel prints Thursday. Carson's SPY \$645.80 support remains active per levels.json, well-removed from Tuesday's intraday range of \$744.18–\$749.04 per data drop — no level was hit. *Avoid Erosion.*

4. Digital-Asset Sleeve and Miners — The Move Reads as Real-Asset Composition Rather Than a Standalone Crypto Bid. Per data drop, IBIT closed ↑2.11% at \$37.67 and ETHA ↑1.40% at \$14.53, while the mining cohort captured the flow: HUT ↑7.98% (\$108.98), HOOD ↑7.13% (\$106.36), and MARA ↑4.97% (\$12.25). Per Benzinga coverage cited in the data drop, the Nebius-IREN neocloud framing continues to link the Bitcoin-mining infrastructure to hyperscaler AI capex — the same debate that lands with Alphabet tonight. For the FCI Growth-Hybrid sleeve, the composition of miners plus merchant silicon plus gold/silver plus copper (FCX ↑6.41%) is consistent with a real-asset overlay rather than a single-catalyst move, and it argues for evaluating the digital-asset ETFs alongside the broader physical-AI infrastructure thesis rather than in isolation. *Think Like an Owner.*

5. Fed Blackout Continues; PCE Prints July 30 — The Real-Asset Bid Is the Cleanest Read on Market-Implied Inflation Expectations. Per Federal Reserve schedule, the pre-FOMC communications blackout continues through the July 28–29 meeting (no SEP). Per CME FedWatch coverage cited by Chase, hold probability at 3.50–3.75% sits near 89%; per Semafor coverage, year-end hike probability sits near 36% (up from 18% on July 2). Gold at a two-week high per Reuters coverage alongside silver ↑4.12% and oil bidding into six-week highs per Reuters coverage of the data drop headlines is consistent with markets pricing a persistent inflation regime that could feed through to a hotter PCE print on July 30 per BEA release schedule. Per data drop, the FCI

Dividend sleeve saw give-back Tuesday with SPGI ↓3.81% (\$431.26), ADP ↓3.53% (\$246.22), CL ↓1.56% (\$90.50), and CHD ↓2.09% (\$95.75), while ADI ↑2.78% (\$382.81) bucked the trend and CAT ↑2.97% (\$889.97) captured the industrial-AI framing. Per Yahoo Finance coverage cited in the data drop, LMT reports tomorrow (Thu) before the open with the Patriot missile program in focus given Ukraine and Middle East conflict demand; TEL and NOW report today. *Simplicity Over Complexity.*